GREEN HAZARDS

What's at stake at the three controversial mining blocks in Hasdeo Arand?

PEKB PHASE II

Total forest area
1,136 ha.

Total trees
454,000
(ICFRE report)

PARSA COAL BLOCK

Total forest area
841 ha.

Total trees
96,000

KENTE EXTENSION

Total forest area
1,760 ha.

Total trees
99 per cent
area is dense forest

by the Indian Council of Forestry Research and Education (ICFRE) and the Wildlife Institute of India (WII). In October 2021, the Forest Advisory Committee gave the go-ahead for mining. "But the objections raised in the WII report were not taken into account," says senior advocate Sudeep Shrivastava who has filed the petition in the SC.

The protests around PEKB Phase II cover the villages of Ghatbarra, Salhi, Fatehpur, Hariharpur and Basein where around 1,000 families will be affected. "The grounds for protest are environmental and legal. Hasdeo Arand is perhaps the best forest of central India and is the catchment area of the Hasdeo river. Tribal livelihoods depend on this forest. The WII study clearly opposed the project saying mining would exacerbate the man-elephant conflict which takes many lives in Chhattisgarh every year," says Alok Shukla of the Chhattisgarh Bachao Andolan, a group opposed to the project. "Also, Hasdeo Arand is in a Schedule V area where, as per law, the gram sabha's consent is a must for any mining activity. The consent being claimed was secured fraudulently as the villagers have opposed the projects continuously since 2014," claims Shukla.

The coal mining project has not only pitted Congress politicians against each other, the opposition BJP has jumped in too, saying the tribals must be heard. Interestingly, the four coal blocks in questions have been assigned to the Rajasthan Power Generation Company while Adani Enterprises is the 'mine developer and operator'. Rajasthan CM Ashok Gehlot was in Raipur in March and held talks with Baghel to expedite mining work at the site. A day after the visit, the Chhattisgarh government granted Stage II Forest Clearance to PEKB Phase II while on April 6, the same clearance was accorded to Parsa coal block. It's after this that the agitation gained steam.

A few days ago, Baghel sought to put the onus of the power shortage in the state on opponents of the project. "There is a coal shortage across the country and the Centre wants to know the progress of the project. How can I stop it? However, if any environmental or rehabilitation rules have been flouted, we will look into it," Baghel had earlier told INDIA TODAY.

But after Singhdeo got involved, Baghel seems to have mellowed down. Also, Rahul Gandhi from the Congress central command is now an interested party—while interacting with students at Cambridge University, he had conceded there was a problem with the decision to allow mining and that a solution was being worked out within the party. Political watchers claim the state government's tactical 'go slow but don't abandon' line emanates from Rahul's stand. But slow motion death will still be death. ■



AT THE TOP
Ashok Gehlot in Jaipur after the RS results were announced

PTI

RAJASTHAN

LUXURY OF A WINNER

By Rohit Parihar

Rajasthan chief minister Ashok Gehlot has mastered the art of winning elections, including all the strenuous spadework that goes before the polls, in his third tenure. He has maintained his current winning streak in the just-concluded Rajya Sabha polls. Out for the four RS seats on offer, the ruling Congress was assured of two, but under Gehlot it won a third seat too. Gehlot, who came to power with just 100 MLAs in a 200-member assembly in 2018, got the support of 126 lawmakers, displaying that his government is on solid ground. He has also stalled a worried BJP's repeated attempts to counter him.

The Congress was sure that Randeep Surjewala and Mukul Wasnik, both Gandhi family loyalists, would get the adequate votes to be elected to the Rajya Sabha. But it had doubts if Pramod Tiwari, a prominent veteran from Uttar Pradesh, could sail through so easily (he got 41 votes).

The BJP, on its part, was sanguine